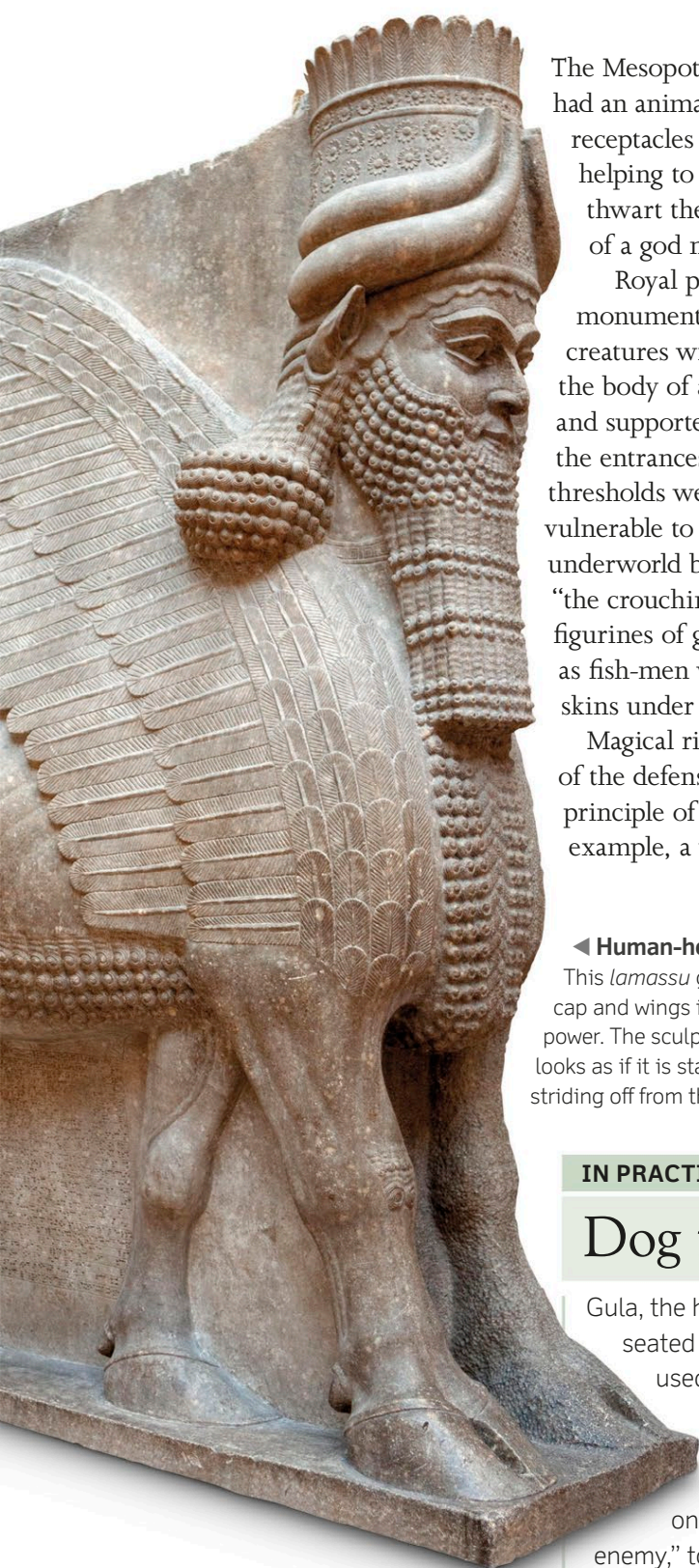




The Mesopotamians believed that objects had an animate quality and could act as the receptacles of enormous magical power, helping to ward off evil spirits and thwart their actions, or gain the favor of a god needed to drive them away.

Royal palaces were guarded by monumental statues of *lamassu*, winged creatures with the head of a man and the body of a bull or lion, which blocked and supported gateways, corridors, and the entrances to throne rooms. These thresholds were seen as particularly vulnerable to infiltration from the underworld by demons such as Rabisu, “the crouching one.” Poorer people placed figurines of gods or hybrid creatures such as fish-men with pointed hats and scaly skins under doorways or windows.

Magical rituals were an important part of the defense against dark magic. The principle of substitution was used, so, for example, a young goat would be dressed

in the clothes and sandals of a sick man and sacrificed to the goddess of death, in order that she would take the goat not the ill person. Similarly, ghost effigies were made to prevent the deceased from wandering or speaking—typically, a clay figure would be inscribed with the dead person’s name, its feet broken, and a dog’s tooth put in its mouth to gag it.

Much evil magic was believed to have been carried out through witches tricking deities into helping them. Prayers to the gods, therefore, especially to Marduk, who was closely associated with magic, asked him to mediate with his powerful father Ea, who was the ultimate source of the ritual magic that *ashipu* used in their exorcisms.

Amulets to ward off evil

Wearing amulets was another part of protective magic, and such amulets often portrayed the spirit they were supposed to ward off. For instance, Pazuzu, the king of the wind demons, would be depicted as a creature with a bird’s chest and talons, holding a thunderbolt, and Lamashtu, who preyed on pregnant women, as a hybrid of a donkey, lion, and bird. Amulets could protect a traveler in hostile territory inhabited by demons, such as the desert, or keep disease away from a house during an epidemic. In the Mesopotamian world much was unpredictable, and magic tilted the balance just a little in people’s favor.

◀ Human-headed lion

This *lamassu* guarded a palace door. The horned cap and wings indicate its divinity, and the belt its power. The sculptor gave the figure five legs so it looks as if it is standing firmly from the front but striding off from the side.

IN PRACTICE

Dog figurines

Gula, the healing goddess, was frequently depicted with a dog seated at her feet, and so clay or bronze dog figurines were used to invoke her aid. Buried at thresholds or other places vulnerable to the infiltration of magic, they acted as mystical guard dogs, keeping out disease or other misfortunes. They often had names carved on them, such as “Loud of bark” or “Catcher of the enemy,” to give them added potency. Gula was an underworld goddess, too, and the dog figurines may also have been intended to help guide the deceased into the next world.

This terra-cotta fragment of Gula’s dog is part of a larger sculpture or temple decoration.

